

Module 1 · Start here

The sounds of French

Vowels English doesn't have, silent letters, linking, rhythm — and what's different in Canadian French.

YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Hear and produce u vs ou, é vs è, and the three nasal vowels
- ✓ Predict which final letters are silent
- ✓ Make the obligatory liaisons and elisions
- ✓ Speak with French rhythm: even syllables, stress at the end of each group

Spelling	Sound	Examples
an, am, en, em	[ɑ̃] (Quebec often closer to [ã])	enfant, temps, chambre, ensemble child, time, bedroom, together
on, om	[ɔ̃]	bon, nom, maison, nombre good, name, house, number
in, im, ain, ein, (y)en after i/é	[ɛ̃]	vin, important, pain, plein, bien, européen wine, important, bread, full, well, European
un, um	[œ̃] or [ɛ̃]	un, lundi, parfum a / one, Monday, perfume

Written	Said	What's silent
ils parlent they speak	[il paʁl]	-ent
les enfants the children	[le.zɑ̃.fɑ̃]	final -ts (the s of les is linked)
un petit garçon a little boy	[œ̃.pti.ɡaʁsɔ̃]	final t, and the e of petit in speech
un sac, la mer a bag, the sea	[sak] [mɛʁ]	nothing — C and R are pronounced
six, dix six, ten	[sis] [dis]	said alone; before a consonant: six livres [si]

KEY PHRASES

Je voudrais un café.

I'd like a coffee. (five even beats, stress on -fé)

La fin de semaine, je travaille dans un restaurant.

On weekends, I work in a restaurant. (rise on -maine, fall on -rant)

un bon vin blanc

a good white wine (all four nasal)

Il est canadien. Elle est canadienne.

He's Canadian. She's Canadian. (nasal vs not)

Ils sont deux.

There are two of them. (no liaison: s-sound, not z)

J'habite chez eux depuis un an.

I've been living with them for a year.

Bonjour, je m'appelle Sara. J'habite à Montréal.

Hello, my name is Sara. I live in Montreal.

Mon enfant a un bon ami canadien.

My child has a good Canadian friend. (nasals + liaison)

Ils ont deux enfants, mais ils sont très occupés.

They have two children, but they're very busy.

Elle arrive à huit heures avec elle.

She arrives at eight with her. (enchaînement)

AVOID THESE MISTAKES

X Pronouncing the s in Paris, trois, vous

Saying final letters is the most common beginner error and can make words unrecognisable.

✓ **Final consonants silent (except C, R, F, L)**

X tu said like English "too"

"too" is tout (all) — a different word.

✓ **Lips rounded, tongue forward: [ty]**

X ils parlent with "-ent" pronounced

The verb ending -ent is always silent.

✓ **[il paʁl]**

X Pronouncing the h in hôtel

French h is never pronounced.

✓ **[otɛl], and l'hôtel**

X Stressing the first syllable: RES-taurant

English word stress makes French hard to follow.

✓ **Even syllables, stress at the end: res-tau-RANT**

X vous avez with a gap

Pronoun + verb liaison is obligatory.

✓ **vous avez [vu.za.ve]**

X je aime, le hôpital

Elision is compulsory before a vowel or mute h.

✓ **j'aime, l'hôpital**

TIP

Clap the syllables while you say a sentence. If some claps feel much longer than others, you're stressing English-style.

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The sounds of French: the rules at a glance

Lesson 1.1

CHEAT CODE Equal beats, stress at the end of the group

je vou drai z_un ca fé stressed

Every syllable gets the same length. Only the last one of the group is a little stronger.

Lesson 1.2

CHEAT CODE Pure vowels: lips and tongue hold still

u · tu, rue
say "ee", then round your lips

ou · tout, nous
"oo", very round, no glide

é · été, parler
short and tight, no "-ee" at the end

è · mère, lait
more open, like "bed"

Lesson 1.3

CHEAT CODE Three nasal vowels: the n / m is not said

an · en
[ɑ̃]

enfant temps
chambre

on · om
[ɔ̃]

bon nom maison

in · ain · ein
[ɛ̃]

vin pain plein

Lesson 1.4

CHEAT CODE Consonants that trip English speakers

r
back of the throat, a soft gargle

h
always silent: l'hôpital

th
just t: le thé

ch
English "sh": chat

gn
"ny": montagne

s / ss
poison [z] vs poisson [s]

Lesson 1.5

CHEAT CODE What you don't say at the end of a word

Usually silent

s, t, d, x, z, p and -ent on verbs

Paris, petit, grand, ils parlent

vs

CaReFuL: said

c, r, f, l are usually pronounced

sac, mer, neuf, sel

Except -er: parler, premier — the r is silent.

Lesson 1.6

CHEAT CODE Three ways French links words

Liaison

a silent letter wakes up

les_amis nous_avons
deux_heures

Élision

a vowel drops

le ami → l'ami je ai → j'ai

Enchaînement

a sound slides over

il_a une_amie

Lesson 1.7

CHEAT CODE Canadian French: recognise it, aim for clear

petit → "p'tsi"

t and d before i / u become ts / dz

vite, route

i, ou relax in closed syllables

je suis → "chu"

informal speech drops sounds

la fin de semaine

the weekend

le dîner · le souper

lunch · dinner

Examiners score how clear you are, not your accent.